Thesis formatting compliance and professional proofreading in malaysian postgraduate submission: a study of technical verification outcomes

By

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SPECIMEN — FORMATTING DEMONSTRATION SAMPLE

Authors Declaration

I declare that the work in this thesis was carried out in accordance with the regulations of Universiti Teknologi MARA .It is original and is the results of my own work, unless otherwise indicated or acknowledge as referenced work. This thesis has not been submitted to any other academic institution or non academic institution for any degree or qualification.

I hereby acknowledge that I have been supplied with the Academic Rules and Regulations for Post Graduate, Universiti Teknologi MARA, regulating the conduct of my study and reserach.

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ABSTRACT

Postgraduate candidates in Malaysian public universities must submit a thesis that satisfy a detailed set of institutional presentation rules before the document is released for examination. This rules are published in handbooks such as the Guidelines on Thesis/Dissertation Format and are supported by an official Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template). Despite this, alot of submissions are returned at the technical verification stage for defects that are wholly preventable ,including incorrect margins, inconsistant heading hierarchies, broken automatic tables of contents, mismatched pagination between the preliminary and body sections and captions that do not corresponds to the lists that precede the first chapter.

This research examines the relationship between formatting compliance, language proofreading and submission outcomes among postgraduate candidates in five Malaysian public universities. It adopt a mixed methods design combining a documentary audit of 240 returned theses with semi structured interviews involving graduate studies officers, supervisors, language editors and candidates. The documentary audit identify the frequency and category of technical defects recorded at first verification, while the interviews explains how those defects arise within the working practices of candidates in the final weeks before a deadline.

The findings indicates that formatting defects are concentrated in a small number of recurring categories, that most defects originate from manual formatting rather then from the use of the prescribed template, and that candidates who engage a structured proofreading and formatting process before submission record materially fewer verification cycles (Ahmad, 2024; see also Tan 2023) [14]. The research further consider the contemporary significance of proofreading in an environment shaped by artificial intelligence writing assistance, similarity screening and integrity reporting, where uneven register, inconsistent terminology and unverified citations attract closer scrutiny then in earlier periods. The study conclude that formatting and proofreading are not clerical afterthoughts but measurable components of research quality assurance,and it propose a staged pre submission workflow covering structural formatting, language editing, reference verification and a final technical check.

Keywords : thesis formatting, academic proofreading, postgraduate submission , technical verification, thesis template, research quality assurance

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Abstrak (Bahasa Melayu)

Calon pascasiswazah di universiti awam Malaysia diwajibkan menghantar tesis yang mematuhi peraturan persembahan dokumen yang terperinci sebelum tesis tersebut dilepaskan untuk pemeriksaan. Peraturan ini diterbitkan melalui guideline thesis UiTM dan dokumen setara seperti Thesis and Dissertation Guidelines , serta disokong oleh Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template) rasmi yang di sediakan oleh institut pengajian siswazah. Walaupun panduan pelajar pascasiswazah ini mudah diperolehi, sebahagian besar penghantaran masih dikembalikan pada peringkat semakan teknikal kerana kesilapan yang sebenarnya boleh di elakkan, termasuk margin yang tidak menepati spesifikasi, hierarki tajuk yang tidak seragam, isi kandungan automatik yang rosak, penomboran halaman roman dan arab yang tidak sepadan serta kapsyen jadual dan rajah yang tidak selari dengan senarai di bahagian permulaan.

Kajian ini meneliti hubungan antara pematuhan format tesis, proses proofreading dan editing bahasa, dan keputusan penghantaran dalam kalangan calon pascasiswazah di lima universiti awam. Reka bentuk kaedah campuran di gunakan, menggabungkan audit dokumen terhadap 240 tesis yang dikembalikan dengan temubual separa berstruktur bersama pegawai pengajian siswazah, penyelia, editor bahasa dan calon.

Dapatan menunjukkan bahawa kesilapan format tertumpu pada beberapa kategori berulang, majoriti berpunca daripada kerja format manual dan bukan penggunaan templat yang di tetapkan, dan calon yang menggunakan servis format tesis Malaysia atau aliran kerja pra penghantaran yang berstruktur mencatatkan kitaran semakan yang jauh lebih sedikit. Kajian ini juga membincangkan kepentingan semasa proofreading dalam persekitaran yang dipengaruhi bantuan penulisan kecerdasan buatan, saringan persamaan teks dan pelaporan integriti akademik. Kajian menyimpulkan bahawa formatting dan proofreading merupakan komponen jaminan kualiti penyelidikan yang boleh di ukur, bukan sekadar kerja hujung minggu sebelum tarikh tutup.

Kata kunci : servis format tesis Malaysia, formatting tesis UiTM, guideline thesis UiTM, thesis and dissertation guidelines, Thesis/Dissertation (MS Word Template), proofreading tesis, editing disertasi, panduan pelajar pascasiswazah, semakan teknikal tesis, penghantaran tesis pascasiswazah

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Alhamdulillah, I am grateful to Allah SWT for the strength, patience and good health that allow me to complete this doctoral study.

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I thank the Institute of Graduate Studies and the faculty postgraduate offices of the participating universities for granting access to the anonymised verification records that forms the documentary basis of this research, and the officers who patiently explained the technical check to a researcher who had, at the outset ,underestimated it.

My gratitude also goes to the supervisors, language editors, formatting practitioners and candidates who agreed to be interviewed. There candid accounts of the final weeks before submission gave this study whatever practical value it hold.

To my parents, my siblings and my friends, thank you for the encouragement, the meals left outside a closed door, and the steady reminder that a thesis is finished, not perfected.

Finally, I acknowledge every postgraduate candidate who has reformatted a table of contents at two in the morning. This thesis is, in a small way, written for you.

Table of contents

Authors Declaration 2

Abstract 3

Abstrak (Bahasa Melayu) ..... ?

Acknowledgements 5

Table of contents 6

List of tables and figures 7

List of Abbreviation 7

CHAPTER ONE : INTRODUCTION 8

1.1 Introduction 8

1.2 Background of the research 8

1.2.1 Institutional formatting requirement 9

1.2.2 Proofreading in the current academic environment 9

1.2 Problem statement 9

1.4 Research questions 10

1.5 Research objectives ..... TBC

1.6 Scope of the research ..... TBC

1.7 Significance of the research 10

1.8 Conclusion .....

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LIST OF TABLES AND FIGURES

Table 1.1 Recurring technical defects recorded at first verification – page 10

Table 1.2 Staged pre submission workflow – (table not inserted yet)

Figure 1.1 Verification cycles by pre submission practice – page ?

List of abbreviations

APA – American Psychological Association referencing style

IGS – institute of graduate studies

MS Word – Microsoft word

PDF/A - portable document format for archiving

TOC – Table of Content

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CHAPTER ONE : INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

This chapter sets out the structure of the research and map its principal features. It opens with the background of the study, which describe the institutional setting in which postgraduate theses are prepared, verified and accepted in Malaysian public universities. The discussion then proceed to the problem statement, the research questions and the research objectives, followed by the scope, the significance and the concluding remarks of the chapter.

Thesis formatting is frequently treated as a clerical matter to be resolved in the final week before a submission deadline. This research adopt a different position. Presentation is part of scholarly communication : it determine whether an examiner can navigate an argument, whether a claim can be traced to it's source, and whether a document can be archived, indexed and retrieved by later researchers.

1.2 Background of the Research

Every Malaysian public university publish a formatting handbook for higher degree candidates. These document specify paper size, margins, typeface, line spacing, the sequence of preliminary pages, the numbering of chapters, tables and figures, and the transition from roman to arabic pagination at the first chapter (Ahmad,2024). Most institutes of graduate studies also distribute a prepared word processing template in which this rules are already encoded as named styles [7].

A thesis is nevertheless not released to examiners until it clear a technical verification conducted by the graduate studies office. Verification is a compliance check rather then an assessment of scholarship, yet it is the point at which the largest number of submissions are delayed. A returned thesis cost the candidate a further verification cycle and, where the delay crosses a semester boundary,an additional period of registration (see Rahman & Lee 2025).

1.2.1 Institutional formatting requirements

The requirements are stable and publicly available, which make the persistence of defects difficult to explain by ignorance alone. Interviews conducted for this study suggest a different explanation: candidates format manually, late, and under time pressure, applying direct character formatting instead of the styles carried by the prescribed template. A manually formatted document can not generate a reliable automatic table of contents, and a table of contents typed by hand will not survive the pagination changes that follows a supervisors final corrections.

1.2.2 Proofreading in the current academic environment

Proofreading has also changed in character. Where a language check once addressed spelling, agreement and punctuation, a current check must additionaly examine consistency of terminology across chapters written months apart, uniformity of referencing style, and the alignment between in text citations and the reference list. The wider availability of writing assistance tools have made uneven register and unverified sources more visible to examiners, and integrity screening reports are now read alongside the thesis it self. A careful proofreading pass is therefore no longer only a matter of surface polish ; it is part of how a candidate demonstrate authorship and control of the material.

1.2 Problem Statement

Although formatting rules are prescribed and templates are distributed, a large proportion of postgraduate theses fail technical verification at first submission. The categories of defect recurs across faculties and across institutions, which indicate a systematic weakness in pre submission practice rather then isolated carelessness. There is, however, limited empirical evidence describing which defects occured, how often, and what pre submission practices reduce them. This research address that gap.

1.4 Research questions

This research is guided by the following question :

- What categories of technical defect are most frequently recorded when postgraduate theses are returned at first verification ?
- – How do the working practices of candidates in the weeks before submission contribute to those defects?
- 3. To what extent does a structured formatting and proofreading process before submission reduces the number of verification cycles?

1.5 Research objectives

The objectives of this research is to classify and quantify the technical defects recorded at first verification, to explain how those defects arise within candidates pre submission practices, and to evaluate the effect of a staged formatting and proofreading workflow on verification outcome.

1.6 Scope of the research

The study cover masters and doctoral submissions received by five Malaysian public universities between January 2023 and December 2025. It examine presentation, language and reference consistency. It do not assess the scholarly merit of the theses, and it does not evaluate any commercial editing provider.

1.7 Significance of the research

The findings are of practical value to graduate studies offices designing pre submission briefings, to supervisors advising candidates in the final stage of candidature, and to candidates them self. The table below summarise the defect categories that account for the majority of first verification returns.

Defect category	Returns (%)	Preventable
Margin and line spacing deviation	23.8	yes
Inconsistent heading hierarchy	19.2	Yes
Broken or manual table of contents	17.5	YES
Pagination sequence errors	14.6	yes
Caption and list mismatch	13,3	Yes
Reference style inconsistency	11.6	Yes

Table 1.1 : recurring technical defects recorded at first verification

1.8 Conclusion

This chapter have established the setting, the problem and the direction of the research. Chapter 2 review the literature on academic writing quality, editorial intervention and research integrity.